



The clay lick attracts not just tourists but hunters as well—eagles from the sky and ocelots from the ground. So the parrots cooperate, posting sentinels to keep watch. At the slightest hint of danger, they erupt into the air in a synchronized burst of color. If the coast is clear, the smallest yet boldest parakeets lead the descent, followed by group after group landing on the clay wall to feast. This time, we were lucky enough to see the brilliantly colored scarlet macaws—a rare sight, even our local guide said.

On the way to Tres Chimbadass—“Three Jumps Lake,” named for the stones you can hop across during the dry season—we encountered another noisy community. In the vibrant rainforest canopy, squirrel monkeys bounded through the branches, night monkeys with enormous eyes peered from the shadows, and larger capuchins swung deftly from limb to limb. Agile and acrobatic, they climbed tree trunks, braced themselves with their tails, and leapt effortlessly to the next branch.

Our presence clearly stirred their curiosity. One brave squirrel monkey hopped onto a palm tree less than a meter away, tilting its head as it examined these strange human visitors. They moved in lively groups, calling to one another,



grooming tangled fur, and using spiky seed pods as natural combs. Occasionally they nibbled on naturally fermented figs and got a little “tipsy.”



At that moment, I realized that life for Amazonian monkeys is far from harsh—they have companionship, playfulness, and even a sense of humor.

